

Endurance is faith

A letter from Priest Seraphim. 8th Sunday after Pentecost.

July 25/Aug 7, 2022

http://www.orthodox.net/letters/letter_2022-08-07+8th-sun-after-pentecost+endurance-is-faith.docx

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I keep talking all the time in sermons that Scripture should jump out at us. I've always, since I been a Christian, been very fortunate and I thank God for this, that when I read the Scriptures, stuff is continually "jumping out" at me. Now that I'm a pastor, every time I read something "jumps out" at me, I want to take a note so that I can share it with those whom I love.

My hope is that if the stuff doesn't jump out at you, you will want it to! And you will keep reading, and you will keep changing, and

eventually you'll will receive the great comfort of the Scriptures.

Let's never forget that when we read the Scriptures God wants to personally comfort us. It's not just about dogma and doctrine and things we should do and things we should not do and that we are sinners. It is also about being comforted, and being amazed and feeling compunction, and ... experiencing God.

The following is the fruit of one of my notes when I was reading the scriptures.

"Sir, I have no man in order that whenever the water is troubled, he may put me into the pool; but while I am coming another goeth down before me" John 5:7

The Holy Fathers have commented that the paralytic by the sheep's pool had great endurance.

Certainly, his malady was because of his sins. Our Lord made that very clear to him when He told him when he was in the temple to "sin no more" lest a worst thing before him.

We all have great sins, but very few of us have great virtues. This man had sins and virtues (at the very least, his great endurance); however, as a man, he was subject to the vagaries of human emotion. Therefore, the man was waiting for 38 years to be healed, and

although he had not completely lost hope, he was cynical and depressed. So, when the Lord comes to him and says, "Dost thou wish to become well," the man replies negatively.

He implies that he wants to become well but also thinks he will not become well because there is no one to help him. Our Lord did not require active faith from this man – he had *already shown by his endurance* that he had faith, but it was weak because of despondency.

Sometimes when there were healings, our Lord required faith. In this case, the man's perseverance

substituted for an explicit expression of faith.

Sometimes *just enduring is faith*; sometimes, we have dark times and waiver, but we waver with faith.

Is that possible? How can we waiver with faith? I think with man, this is impossible, but with God, it is common! God will look at us and say: “you're trying, and even though you're not doing so well right now and you don't have the right state of mind, I will accept your endurance as faith.”

This is a great consolation to me, and it should be to you also. Sometimes we have faith, and sometimes we waiver. If we live consistently, when we have moments of darkness, weakness, cynicism, and feeling alone, we will go through that period and emerge intact.

There are many instances where people did not show faith with their words but in their overall way of living.

Thomas comes to mind. He wouldn't even believe in the resurrection, and yet because of his faith, which was weakened at the time, but nonetheless compelled him to remain with the disciples even though he told them he did not believe, our Lord gave him the great privilege of touching his hands and his side and being the first to proclaim that our Lord is indeed God and man.

The apostles on the road to Emmaus had weak faith. Our Lord appeared before them, and they didn't recognize Him; however, because they loved the Lord and were not “giving up,” the Lord was patient with them and explained everything to them.

We are not like the apostles. We're not even like this paralytic because we don't have much endurance, but we must learn to have *at least a little*! The Lord told us

in a parable that if our faith is as a mustard seed, a very tiny seed, we can still be saved. If our endurance is small *but continuous*, God will help us.

A significant problem in our age is that people don't endure much. I think this is the combination of not knowing what their life is all about, and the weakness of our age where we expect things to be convenient and have learned to be lazy and distracted by the multiple toxic electronic and comfort distractions of our generation.

We must learn to endure a little bit more!

Perhaps we don't pray very well, but we can pray every day!

Perhaps we don't fast very well, but we can give some attention to fasting on fasting days!

Perhaps we pray for people, and we don't see any changes, and our prayer doesn't feel very consistent or very holy, but we can continue to pray!

Perhaps some relationships are very burdensome to us, but we can continue to participate in the relationship with patience, love, and good faith!

Perhaps we read the Scriptures, and they are very confusing to us, but we can continue to read!

All of these things are like the endurance of the paralytic.

We modern-day Christians are little bit like “Popeye.” He had a famous line where he said, “I yam what I yam.” We also “are what we are.” We are not so impressive, but we are Christians, and we have the Holy Spirit abiding in us, and we need to try and endure a little bit more. It won't seem like much, but all the Lord required of the paralytic was *what he had already done* for all those years.

In Christ, unworthy Priest Seraphim (seraphim@orthodoxnet 972 658-5433).

Recent stuff:

[Dogmatic Theotokion Tone 6](#) 2022-07-30

Video: <https://youtu.be/eF1nBOBDA7c>

Audio: http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/misc_2022+dogmatic-theotokion-tone-06.mp3

What is a “Dogmatic Theotokion?” We look at the one in Tone 6 in detail and discuss the resurrection, the incarnation, atheism, prayer to the saints, and rhetorical questions.

“Who doth not call thee blessed, * O all-holy Virgin? * Who will not hymn thine all-pure birthgiving? *
For
the only-begotten Son * Who shone forth timelessly from the Father, * came forth, ineffably
incarnate, from
thee, the pure one; * and being God by nature, He became man for our sake, * not divided into two
Persons, * but known in two natures without confusion. * Him do thou beseech, * O pure and most
blessed one, * that our souls find mercy!”

Partial Timestamps:

0:34- 1:28 “Who doth not call thee blessed, O all-holy Virgin, Who will not hymn thine all-pure birthgiving?” Answer all rhetorical questions!

1:28-3:39 “For the only-begotten son, Who shone forth timelessly from the Father came forth ineffably incarnate from thee, the pure one.”

3:42 – 7:30 “And being God by nature, He became man for our sake, not divided into two Persons, * but known in two natures without confusion.”

4:35 – 5:11 Why is atheism a denial of self?

6:06 – 7:30 The implications of Jesus Christi being “but known in two natures without confusion.”

8:13 - “11:26 Him do thou beseech, * O pure and most blessed one, * that our souls find mercy!”

9:54 - 11:26 God is not the God of the dead. He is the God of the living. Understanding the resurrection and the saints.

[The work is finished! All we need do is receive the words and manifest His name. He has the power and will for us to accomplish this.](#) John 17:1-13 2022-07-31

Video: <https://youtu.be/7WUpP9ybmo4>
http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/saints-07-13_2022+fathers-6-councils+that-they-may-be-one.mp3

On the Sunday commemorating the fathers of the first six ecumenical councils, we read the high Priestly prayer of our Lord Jesus Christ. Certain aspects of this prayer “jump out.” Jesus said that the work he was given was finished. What does this mean? He also said that he could give eternal life to as many as his father has given him. What does that ***practically*** mean for us? We forget and need to be reminded. He also said that He had manifested the name of His Father and that His disciples had received the words. How do we receive the words of God? It is not an intellectual activity! And how do we live so that His prayer that we would be one with God is realized? 2022-07-31

Partial Timestamps

2:28 – 4:58 What to do if reading the Scripture is hard, and confusing, and things do not “jump out”.

5:14 – 10:19 “These words spake Jesus, and lifted up his eyes to heaven, and said, Father, the hour is come; glorify thy Son, that thy Son also may glorify thee: 2 As thou hast given him power over all flesh, that he should give eternal life to as many as thou hast given him.” (John 17:1-2)

10:19 – 12:04 “I have glorified thee on the earth: I have finished the work which thou gavest me to do.” (John 17:4)

12:06 – 14:44 “I have manifested thy name unto the men which thou gavest me out of the world: thine they were, and thou gavest them me; and they have kept thy word.” John 17:6

14:44 “- 16:44 “For I have given unto them the words which thou gavest me; and they have received them, and have known surely that I came out from thee, and they have believed that thou didst send me.” (John 17:8)

16:44 – 17:48 There is no “must”. There is no “should”.

17:48 "Holy Father, keep through thine own name those whom thou hast given me, that they may be one, as we are" John 17:11

20:11 – end "While I was with them in the world, I kept them in thy name: those that thou gavest me I have kept, and none of them is lost, but the son of perdition; that the scripture might be fulfilled. 13 And now come I to thee; and these things I speak in the world, that they might have my joy fulfilled in themselves." John 17:12-13

"Son, be of good cheer, thy sins are forgiven thee." Life is simple. Matthew 9:1-8 2022-07-24

http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/pen-sun-06_2022+the-paralytic+be-of-good-cheer-thy-sins-are-forgiven.mp3

The Christian life is simple, although not easy, because, with our passions, sins and, worries and distractions, we are not simple. Our Lord gave simple advice to a man who was paralyzed: "be of good cheer." For those who look at life in its complexities, this advice is inappropriate and even cruel, but we look into this advice and the One who gave it. And in looking into it, we examine the woman who was a former sinner who was of good cheer and her gratitude energized her actions, just as our gratitude should keep us in good cheer and energize us. We also talk about children, who are often the best example of those who have good cheer and are not hindered by complex passions and worries. What do we really have the worry about? Of course there are troubles, but fundamentally the Christian who experiences God will take our Lord's advice to the letter and be of good cheer and his attitude will energize him to overcome everything. Matthew 9:1-8 2022-07-24

Partial timestamps:

0:26 "Son, be of good cheer, thy sins are forgiven thee."

1:25 – 7:14 Something beautiful about children that we must emulate

4:00 – 5:10 The woman who was a sinner was of "good cheer" because her "sins had been forgiven" her.

St Paisios of Mt Athos. Some stories that illustrate that he is the "mother and brother" of Christ, whose easy yoke and light burden he took on.

Audio: http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/saints-07-01_paisios-of-athos+mother-and-brother-of-christ.mp3

Video: <https://youtu.be/77BNLqYD1Vw>

Partial Timestamps

0:39 Artillery spotter.

1:26 – 2:29 Visions of St Euphemia and a soul with philotimo – even regarding the location of an outhouse!

3:11 – 3:31 When traveling, he tried to keep his evening rule a secret.

3:41 - 4:33 A Description of St Paisios: "Who is My mother and who are My brothers?" 49 And He stretched out His hand toward His disciples and said, "Here are My mother and My brothers! 50 For whoever does the will of My Father in heaven is My brother and sister and mother. cf. Matthew 12:46-13:3

4:46 – 11:35 Why is there blasphemy and moral confusion in our age, even among some of our hierarchs? Because they do not fully understand this: "All things are delivered unto me of my Father: and no man knoweth the Son, but the Father; neither knoweth any man the Father, save the Son, and he to whomsoever the Son will reveal him." (Mat 11:27) **A commentary on the public and promoted baptism of 2 surrogate children of a very public and secular gay "couple".**

11:35 - 13:41 St Paisios prays for a man he does not know, and saves him from suicide.

14:24 – 17:23 The core of St Paisios' success: He obeyed this directive: "Take my yoke upon you, and learn of me; for I am meek and lowly in heart: and ye shall find rest unto your souls. (30) For my yoke is

easy, and my burden is light.” Mat 11:29-30 **A discussion of the burden of the yoke of Christ vs the burden of sin.**